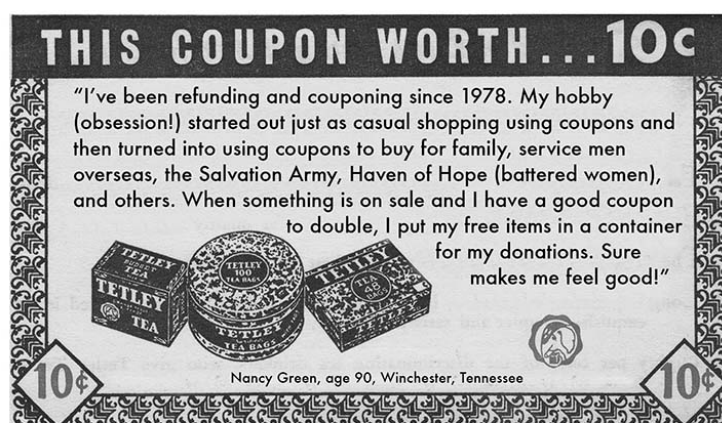


meant that not only did I share a sense of community with others who were like me, but that I could cash in on even more offers with the forms and coupons I traded for. As mentioned earlier, there was a point when I was trading through the mail with fourteen other women. Those envelopes full of letters, coupons, proofs of purchase, and refund forms were like treasures in my mailbox. The women I traded with were spread out all over the country, ensuring that I had access to rebate forms and coupons widely distributed in other states but not available in Iowa.

Besides trading through the mail in response to ads in the bulletins, women all over the nation were conducting “refund conventions,” and “coupon swaps”—meeting at someone’s house or in a public meeting room and trading coupons and refund forms with each other, a practice I’d heard about but never had the opportunity to participate in.



The section of the refunding magazines I found the most fascinating were the profiles of subscribers and their stories, written by other people who were also crazy about coupons. I experienced a real sense of community, and some envy, in reading about the toy deal of a lifetime or someone’s